

Wendy Doniger
is a noted scholar of Hinduism and mythology. Her memoir, ***An American Girl in India****, was published in 2022*

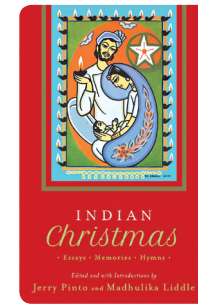
Resisting the temptation to include my own books among the favourites published in 2022, I immediately thought of three other books that I loved, quite different from one another.

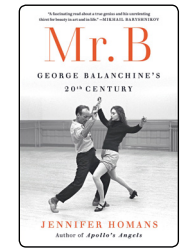
The first is Jennifer Homans' *Mr. B: George Balanchine's 20th Century* (Penguin Random House), about the great ballet-master and choreographer of the New York City Ballet, who was Homans' teacher (and, long ago, mine). Homans hauntingly and in almost novelistic detail re-evokes the people and the ideas of the Russian world in which Balanchine grew up, and the European and American worlds of music and ballet that he changed forever.

The second is Lorraine Daston's *Rules: A Short History of What We Live By* (Princeton University Press). Daston manages brilliantly, often with humour and wit, to balance fascinating, often arcane details from many different worlds—from the Rule of Saint Benedict to the worlds of fashion and spelling and law—with important, grand conclusions that will be debated for some time to come.

The third is *Indian Christmas: Essays, Memories, Hymns* (Speaking Tiger), edited by Jerry Pinto and Madhulika Liddle. I was astonished and delighted to discover how many of the Indian authors I thought I knew (and others I had never yet encountered) had in fact written, unbeknownst to me, fascinating stories, essays and poems about Christmas. From a poem by Rabindranath Tagore to a memoir by Damodar Mauzo, these 27 writings reveal an astonishing range of thoughtful responses to Christmas—some satirical, many pious—by fine Indian writers. ■

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1.
INDIAN CHRISTMAS: ESSAYS, MEMORIES, HYMNS
edited by Jerry Pinto and Madhulika Liddle

2.
MR. B: GEORGE BALANCHINE'S 20TH CENTURY
by Jennifer Homans

3.
RULES: A SHORT HISTORY OF WHAT WE LIVE BY
by Lorraine Daston

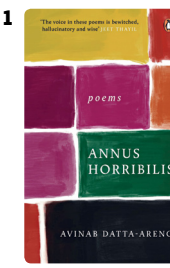


Arvind Krishna Mehrotra
A poet, translator and critic, he edited ***The Book of Indian Essays*** *(2020)*

The world of Indian writing in English is a happy one. Why shouldn't it be? There is no one to call the bluff, no one to say how awful or good it is, or why it is awful or good. Thus, a few hundred more books pour down the drain of forgetfulness in which slim books, especially slim first books, are easier to forget than fat ones. Avinab Datta-Areng's *Annus Horribilis* (Penguin Random House India) is only 76 pages, but written, mostly, in big slabs of verse. Each sentence ignites the next one, and when you look up from the page, "Two men go past the gate carrying / a cling-wrapped carving of Jesus." When did we last see something as momentous as *Annus Horribilis*? For this we have to go back to Arun Kolatkar's *Jejuri* (1976), or Eunice de Souza's *Fix* (1979), or Agha Shahid Ali's *The Half-Inch Himalayas* (1987).

In Vineet Gill's *Here and Hereafter* (Penguin Random House India), we witness the birth of literary criticism in India, a work that can be read for its own sake as much as for what it tells us about Nirmal Verma, the subject of the book. And then there is the unclassifiable *The Sweet Salt of Tamil* (Navayana Publishing) by Tho Paramasivan, translated by V. Ramnarayan, which sold 50,000 copies in Tamil. Would it sell 5,000 in English? And why hasn't anyone written a book called *The Sweet Salt of Punjabi*, my mother tongue? ■

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1.
ANNUS HORRIBILIS
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2.
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